



we have to grab it and work for what we want. I had to get up, start crawling, run, and move. I can't be still in one place," he says.

Two months after his mother passed away, Lokesh once again started applying to colleges in the USA. "I was essentially just sending cold emails to whoever I could. I asked coaches and athletes I had met to recommend me to others. I became very serious about it. I'd stay up late so I could reply to emails immediately," he says.

As it turned out, coaches were still interested. Eventually, he was offered a full scholarship by the University of New Mexico.

Struggles and second chances

At first, the move seemed to work out for him. In May 2023, Lokesh made his first jump over 8m — with a leap of 8.02m at the Mountain West Outdoor Track & Field Championships in Clovis. In his first year in the collegiate circuit, he even made it to the NCAA outdoor track and field finals.

Later that year, when his coach moved to the University of Louisville, Lokesh followed. He had built a base for his collegiate career. Now it was time for him to take off.

That didn't happen.

Lokesh says he was taking part in an off-season gym session when a teammate dropped a weight on his right toe, fracturing it. "It came at the

worst possible time. I was about six months away from the Olympic selection trials in India. I was really confident I would do well, but I ended up having to get surgery instead," he recalls.

Things only got worse. One month after surgery, as he began rehabilitation, Lokesh realised something was very wrong. "One of the screws the doctors had placed inside my bone popped out the other side and started piercing through the flesh and bleeding," he says.

His coaches didn't take his concern seriously. "They felt it was an infection and I could treat it with antibiotics. Of course, it didn't work. It only got worse. For 14 days, I couldn't sleep because of the pain, but all the while people kept telling me these things were normal," he recalls.

Eventually, Lokesh says he could take it no more. He left his college and flew back to India for a second opinion — and got one just in time. "The doctor told me I needed surgery immediately because the infection was about to reach the bone. They had to take out the screw. It was a very critical situation," he says.

As he began rehabilitation in India, Lokesh wondered how he can return to jumping. "I never thought I would give up athletics because of what it meant to my parents and what my mother had told me before she passed away. But I was also uncertain about going back to the USA because of the experience I had there. I reached out to every possible person in India who I thought could help me — the state government, private institutes, even different states. I told them I just needed some support. But all I heard was 'we can't help you'. Everyone said they'd help only if I started jumping again," he recalls.

Finally, Lokesh realised he had to give college in the USA another try. "I didn't have any support in India, and at least in the USA I'd have support to continue my academics and training. In the collegiate system, at least my training would be taken care of by my school. That's when I reached out to coach Bobby Carter (**above, with Lokesh**), and that's when things started falling into place," he says.

Before joining the University of New Mexico, Lokesh had got to know Carter while exploring different schools. The two had stayed in touch, and in 2024 Lokesh reached out again after Carter had taken over the track and field programme at Tarleton University. "I was a little nervous because I hadn't competed for a year, but coach Carter simply said, 'I'd love to have you over,'" he says.

At 35, Carter is one of the youngest head coaches in Division I — the highest level of the NCAA system. He grew up in a family of high-level athletes, with his cousin Michelle Carter having won Olympic gold in shot put in 2016. In Lokesh, he saw something special — not just his build and physicality, but also the mindset.

"I saw in his eyes all the things he had been through. But I also saw someone who didn't want to give up. You can't help but want to go out to bat for someone like that. From an athletics standpoint, I could tell he had the qualities of an athlete. But I could also tell this was a kid with a dream who just needed some help along the way. In my first conversation with him, he said, 'Coach, I want to be the best.' That's all I needed. I took that and ran with it," Carter says.

Lokesh is grateful for the support he got. "I consider myself really lucky that I could connect with coach Carter. He's one of my biggest supporters. He's my cheerleader, mentor, coach, best friend, and a father figure rolled into one. He never made me feel like a stranger or incapable. He always believed in me and told me I can achieve anything," he says.

Although Tarleton didn't have a particularly renowned track and field programme unlike the colleges Lokesh had previously trained at, he says the move suited him. "It's a smaller school, about two hours from Dallas. But that was fine. There are fewer distractions. There's nothing much to do but train. It has a track, it has a gym. Being smaller meant more focus on me and stronger support systems. It was the perfect place to recover," he says.

Slowly, things fell into place.